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Content Analysis of Sustainability Reports: A Practice in Turkey*

Zeynep Şahin**, Fikret Çankaya*** and Züleyha Yılmaz****

Recent corporate scandals show the importance of corporate social responsibility and corporate sustainability. Corporate social responsibility has gradually been replaced by sustainability, and sustainability reports have been published instead of corporate social responsibility reports. Unlike financial reports, sustainability reports include non-financial information and the effects of environmental and social events. The purpose of this study is to analyze the content of 96 sustainability reports prepared by 42 companies in Turkey according to the Global Reporting Initiative (GRI) guidelines by 2015. As a result of the study, it is found that disclosures on strategy and profile were more than disclosures on management approach and performance indicators in Turkey. Following that, economic performance indicators are the most disclosed indicators by Turkish Companies. It is observed that there is an increasing interest in sustainability reporting in Turkey.

JEL Codes: Q56 and L25

1. Introduction

After 1960 it was understood that the ecological balance was deteriorating due to the neglect of the links between environment and development, and this realisation led to the emergence of the concept of sustainability (Altunbaş, 2008). Sustainability for business is to make economic expectations balance with environmental and social responsibility. Corporate sustainability, which is the equivalent of sustainability concept at the business level, attaches importance to growth and profitability of company as well as environmental protection, social equality and economic development. Reporting of these events is possible with sustainability reports.

Financial information produced by financial accountant is considered to be insufficient to evaluate a company. Therefore, it is aimed to complete these reports with sustainability activities and performance (Yanık & Türker, 2012). As a deficiency, financial reporting deals with only financial aspects of business operations. The purpose of financial reporting is to disclose increases and decreases related to the assets and resources. However, sustainability accounting goals to measure a company's sustainability performance to provide accountability to the shareholders, to contribute to the decision making process of managers, and to provide information wanted by stakeholders (Yönet, 2010).

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2. Literature Review

When the studies on the content analysis of sustainability reports are summarized, Yönet (2010) observed that just a few Turkish banks have prepared a sustainability report. Sustainability reports of 116 Chinese banks were reviewed by Huang and Wang (2010), and they found that economic, environmental, social and governance issues were more focused. Likewise, Dong (2011) investigated sustainability reports in Chinese mining sector. Roca and Searcy (2011) examined the sustainability reports of 94 companies and found that 585 different economic, environmental and social indicators were used. Sobhani et al. (2012) analyzed reports of the banking sector in Bangladesh, and found that social indicators were more than environmental and economic indicators. Similarly, Aktaş et al. (2013) examined the sustainability reports of 9 big companies in Turkey and revealed that disclosures on strategy and profile were more than disclosures on management approach and performance indicators.

Maubane et al. (2014) examined the sustainability reports in Johannesburg and found that the reports contained disclosures on mostly environmental and social indicators rather than disclosures on management approach. Hinson et al. (2015) found that there were 56 indicators of strategy and profile, reporting approaches, economic, environmental, social, and human rights indicators in higher education sustainability reports. Alcaraz Quiles et al. (2015) observed that social disclosures are more than others in the sustainability reports. Moreover, Kozłowski et al. (2015) found that the topics covered in sustainability reports in 14 different apparel sectors are sustainable supply chain management, design practices, business innovation, consumer responsibility, and product sustainability.

When the literature was evaluated, detailed studies on the sustainability reports were not found in Turkey. The sustainability reports, which were analyzed in this study, include 121 indicators of strategy and profile, management approach and performance indicators.

3. Methodology

Literature review process revealed inadequacy of studies done regarding sustainable reporting in Turkey. Every new study on this issue seems helpful for Turkey to improve awareness of sustainability, and to provide guidance to business managers to enhance performance of their companies. The purpose of this study is to examine scope and quality of the sustainability reports prepared according to the GRI guidelines by 2015 in Turkey.

Content analysis, frequently used in the field of social and environmental reporting, was used as a method of this study. Content analysis is defined as a method in which various reports and explanations are analyzed objectively and systematically (Guthrie & Abeysekera, 2006). The GRI guidelines and studies of Leszczynska (2012) and Aktaş et al. (2013) have been used for the determination and codification of the categories in the study. In the content analysis, the most disclosed and undisclosed indicators were identified among the disclosures on strategy and profile, management approach, and performance indicators of the companies.

157 reports of 66 companies prepared according to the GRI guidelines by 2015 were included in the scope of the content analysis. 96 Of these reports prepared by 42 companies were obtained from the GRI website. Reports without GRI Index were excluded from the study. The data set obtained from these reports was analyzed in the SPSS 22.00 package program. In the content analysis, if strategy and profile, management approach, and

performance indicators are fully disclosed, this report was coded as 2; if disclosures were partial, this report was coded as 1; and lastly if there is no disclosure, this report was coded as 0. Thus, indicators which are the most disclosed and never disclosed have been identified. Categories in the sustainability reports prepared according to the GRI guidelines are listed below.

Strategy and Profile

Strategy and Analysis (SA)

(SA1)-Statement from the most senior decision maker of the organisation about the relevance of sustainability to the organisation and its strategy.

(SA2)-Description of key impacts, risks and opportunities.

Organizational Profile (OP)

(OP1)-Name of the organisation.

(OP2)-Primary brands, products, and/or services.

(OP3)-Operational structure of the organization, including main divisions, operating companies, subsidiaries, and joint ventures.

(OP4)-Location of organization's headquarters.

(OP5)-Number of countries where the organization operates, and names of countries with either major operations or that are specifically relevant to the sustainability issues covered in the report.

(OP6)-Nature of ownership and legal form.

(OP7)-Markets served.

(OP8)-Scale of the reporting organization.

(OP9)-Significant changes during the reporting period regarding size, structure, or ownership.

(OP10)-Awards received in the reporting period.

Report Parameters (RP)

(RP1)-Reporting period for information provided.

(RP2)-Date of most recent report.

(RP3)-Reporting cycle.

(RP4)-Contact point for questions regarding the report or its contents.

(RP5)-Process for defining report content.

(RP6)-Boundary of the report.

(RP7)-State any specific limitations on the scope or boundary of the report.

(RP8)-Basis for reporting on joint ventures, subsidiaries, leased facilities, outsourced operations, and other entities that can significantly affect comparability from period to period and/or between organizations.

(RP9)-Data measurement techniques and the bases of calculations, including assumptions and techniques underlying estimations applied to the compilation of the Indicators and other information in the report.

(RP10)-Explanation of the effect of any restatements of information provided in earlier reports, and the reasons for such re-statement.

(RP11)-Significant changes from previous reporting periods in the scope, boundary, or measurement methods applied in the report.

(RP12)-Table identifying the location of the Standard Disclosures in the report.

(RP13)-Policy and current practice with regard to seeking external assurance for the report.

Governance, Commitments and Engagement (GCE)

(GCE1)-Governance structure of the organization.

(GCE2)-Governance structure of the organization.

(GCE3)-For organizations that have a unitary board structure, state the number and gender of members of the highest governance body that are independent and/or non-executive members.

(GCE4)-Mechanisms for shareholders and employees to provide recommendations or direction to the highest governance body.

(GCE5)-Linkage between compensation for members of the highest governance body, senior managers, and executives and the organization's performance.

(GCE6)-Processes in place for the highest governance body to ensure conflicts of interest are avoided.

(GCE7)-Process for determining the composition, qualifications, and expertise of the members of the highest governance body and its committees.

(GCE8)-Internally developed statements of mission or values, codes of conduct, and principles relevant to economic, environmental, and social performance and the status of their implementation.

(GCE9)-Procedures of the highest governance body for overseeing the organization's identification and management of economic, environmental, and social performance.

(GCE10)-Processes for evaluating the highest governance body's own performance, particularly with respect to economic, environmental, and social performance.

(GCE11)-Explanation of whether and how the precautionary approach or principle is addressed by the organization Address the organisations approach to risk management in operational planning or the development and introduction of new products.

(GCE12)-Externally developed economic, environmental, and social charters, principles, or other initiatives to which the organization subscribes or endorses.

(GCE13)-Memberships in associations and/or national/international advocacy organizations.

(GCE14)-List of stakeholder groups engaged by the organization.

(GCE15)-Basis for identification and selection of stakeholders with whom to engage.

(GCE16)-Approaches to stakeholder engagement.

(GCE17)-Key topics and concerns that have been raised through stakeholder engagement, and how the organization has responded to those key topics and concerns, including through its reporting.

Management Approach and Performance Indicators

Economic Performance Indicators (EC)

(EC1)-Direct economic value generated and distributed.

(EC2)-Financial implications and other risks and opportunities for the organisations activities due to climate change firsatlar.

(EC3)-Coverage of the organisation's defined benefit plan obligations.

- (EC4)-Significant financial assistance received from government.
- (EC5)-Range of ratios of standard entry level wage compared to local minimum wage at significant locations of operation.
- (EC6)-Policy, practices, and proportion of spending on locally based suppliers at significant locations of operation.
- (EC7)-Procedures for local hiring and proportion of senior management hired from the local community at locations of significant operation.
- (EC8)-Development and impact of infrastructure investments and services provided primarily for public benefit through commercial, in-kind, or pro-bono engagement.
- (EC9)-Understanding and describing significant indirect economic impacts.

Environmental Performance Indicators (EN)

- (EN1)-Materials used by weight or volume.
- (EN2)-Percentage of materials used that are recycled input materials.
- (EN3)-Direct energy consumption by primary energy source.
- (EN4)-Indirect energy consumption by primary source.
- (EN5)-Energy saved due to conservation and efficiency improvements.
- (EN6)-Initiatives to provide energy-efficient or renewable energy based products and services, and reductions in energy requirements as a result of these initiatives.
- (EN7)-Initiatives to reduce indirect energy consumption and reductions achieved.
- (EN8)-Total water withdrawal by source.
- (EN9)-Water sources significantly affected by withdrawal of water.
- (EN10)-Percentage and total volume of water recycled and reused.
- (EN11)-Location and size of land owned, leased, managed in, or adjacent to, protected areas and areas of high biodiversity value outside protected areas.
- (EN12)-Description of significant impacts of activities, products, and services on biodiversity in protected areas and areas of high biodiversity value outside protected areas.
- (EN13)-Habitats protected or restored.
- (EN14)-Strategies, current actions, and future plans for managing impacts on biodiversity.
- (EN15)-Number of IUCN Red List species and national conservation list species with habitats in areas affected by operations, by level of extinction risk.
- (EN16)-Total direct and indirect greenhouse gas emissions by weight.
- (EN17)-Other relevant indirect greenhouse gas emissions by weight.
- (EN18)-Initiatives to reduce greenhouse gas emissions and reductions achieved.
- (EN19)-Emissions of ozone-depleting substances by weight.
- (EN20)-NO_x, SO_x, and other significant air emissions by type and weight.
- (EN21)-Total water discharge by quality and destination.
- (EN22)-Total weight of waste by type and disposal method.
- (EN23)-Total number and volume of significant spills.
- (EN24)-Weight of transported, imported, exported, or treated waste deemed hazardous under the terms of the Basel Convention Annex I, II, III, and VIII, and percentage of transported waste shipped internationally.
- (EN25)-Identity, size, protected status, and biodiversity value of water bodies and related habitats significantly affected by the reporting organization's discharges of water and runoff.

(EN26)-Initiatives to mitigate environmental impacts of products and services, and extent of impact mitigation.

(EN27)-Percentage of products sold and their packaging materials that are reclaimed by category.

(EN28)-Monetary value of significant fines and total number of non-monetary sanctions for non-compliance with environmental laws and regulations.

(EN29)-Significant environmental impacts of transporting products and other goods and materials used for the organization's operations, and transporting members of the workforce.

(EN30)-Total environmental protection expenditures and investments.

Labour Practices and Decent Work Performance Indicators (LA)

(LA1)-Total workforce by employment type, employment contract, and region, broken down by gender.

(LA2)-Total number and rate of new employee hires and employee turnover by age group, gender, and region.

(LA3)-Benefits provided to full-time employees that are not provided to temporary or parttime employees, by major operations.

(LA4)-Percentage of employees covered by collective bargaining agreements.

(LA5)-Minimum notice period(s) regarding significant operational changes.

(LA6)-Percentage of total workforce represented in formal joint management-worker health and safety committees that help monitor and advice on occupational health and safety programs.

(LA7)-Rates of injury, occupational diseases, lost days, and absenteeism, and number of work-related fatalities by region and by gender.

(LA8)-Education, training, counselling, prevention, and risk-control programs in place to assist workforce members, their families, or community members regarding serious diseases.

(LA9)-Health and safety topics covered in formal agreements with trade unions.

(LA10)-Average hours of training per year per employee by gender, and by employee category.

(LA11)-Programs for skills management and lifelong learning that support the continued employability of employees and assist them in managing career endings.

(LA12)-Percentage of employees receiving regular performance and career development reviews, by gender.

(LA13)-Composition of governance bodies and breakdown of employees per employee category according to gender, age group, minority group membership, and other indicators of diversity.

(LA14)-Ratio of basic salary and remuneration of women to men by employee category, by significant locations of operation.

Human Rights Performance Indicators (HR)

(HR1)-Percentage and total number of significant investment agreements and contracts.

(HR2)-Percentage of significant suppliers, contractors and other business partners that have undergone human rightsscreening, and actions taken.

(HR3)-Total hours of employee training on policies and procedures concerning aspects of human rights that are relevant to operations, including the percentage of employees trained.

(HR4)-Total number of incidents of discrimination and actions taken.

(HR5)-Operations and significant suppliers identified in which the right to exercise freedom of association and collective bargaining may be violated or at significant risk, and actions taken to support these rights.

(HR6)-Operations and significant suppliers identified as having significant risk for incidents of child labour, and measures taken to contribute to the effective abolition of child labour.

(HR7)-Operations and significant suppliers identified as having significant risk for incidents of forced or compulsory labour, and measures to contribute to the elimination of all forms of forced or compulsory labour.

(HR8)-Percentage of security personnel trained in the organization's policies or procedures concerning aspects of human rights that are relevant to operations.

(HR9) Total number of incidents of violations involving rights of indigenous people and actions taken.

Product Responsibility Performance Indicators (PR)

(PR1)-Life cycle stages in which health and safety impacts of products and services are assessed for improvement, and percentage of significant products and services categories subject to such procedures.

(PR2)-Total number of incidents of noncompliance with regulations and voluntary codes concerning health and safety impacts of products and services during their life cycle, by type of outcomes.

(PR3)-Type of product and service information required by procedures and percentage of significant products and services subject to such information requirements.

(PR4)-Total number of incidents of noncompliance with regulations and voluntary codes concerning product and service information and labelling, by type of outcomes.

(PR5)-Practices related to customer satisfaction, including results of surveys measuring customer satisfaction.

(PR6) Programs for adherence to laws, standards, and voluntary codes related to marketing communications, including advertising, promotion, and sponsorship.

(PR7)-Total number of incidents of noncompliance with regulations and voluntary codes concerning marketing communications.

(PR8)-Total number of substantiated complaints regarding breaches of customer privacy and losses of customer data.

(PR9) Monetary value of significant fines for noncompliance with laws and regulations concerning the provision and use of products and services.

Social Performance Indicators (SO)

(SO1)-Percentage of operations with implemented local community engagement, impact assessments, and development programs.

(SO2)-Percentage and total number of business units analyzed for risks related to corruption.

(SO3)-Percentage of employees trained in organization's anti-corruption policies and procedures.

(SO4)-Actions taken in response to incidents of corruption.

(SO5) Public policy positions and participation in public policy development and lobbying.

(SO6)-Total value of financial and in-kind contributions to political parties, politicians, and related institutions by country.

(SO7)-Total number of legal actions for anticompetitive behaviour, anti-trust, and monopoly practices and their outcomes.

(SO8)-Monetary value of significant fines and total number of non-monetary sanctions for non-compliance with laws and regulations.

4. Findings

Firstly, frequency distributions of strategy and profile disclosures were calculated in the study. According to the Table 1, all companies fully disclosed OP1, OP2, OP3, OP4, RP3, RP4, RP6, and RP12. Contrarily, GCE10 is the most undisclosed indicator.

Table 1: Frequency Distribution Results of Disclosures on Strategy and Profile Indicators

Strategy and Profile Indicators	Frequency			Strategy and Profile Indicators	Frequency		
	Undisclosed	Partially Disclosed	Fully Disclosed		Undisclosed	Partially Disclosed	Fully Disclosed
SA1	-	2	94	RP10	7	-	89
SA2	23	6	67	RP11	5	-	91
OP1	-	-	96	RP12	-	-	96
OP2	-	-	96	RP13	16	1	79
OP3	-	-	96	GCE1	1	1	94
OP4	-	-	96	GCE2	3	-	93
OP5	1	-	95	GCE3	3	1	92
OP6	3	1	92	GCE4	3	7	86
OP7	-	1	95	GCE5	28	6	62
OP8	-	4	92	GCE6	23	2	71
OP9	-	1	95	GCE7	28	2	66
OP10	1	-	95	GCE8	18	2	76
RP1	-	1	95	GCE9	27	4	65
RP2	1	-	95	GCE10	30	7	59
RP3	-	-	96	GCE11	21	2	73
RP4	-	-	96	GCE12	15	-	81
RP5	-	5	91	GCE13	13	2	81
RP6	-	-	96	GCE14	1	2	93
RP7	1	-	95	GCE15	6	8	82
RP8	5	-	91	GCE16	17	3	76
RP9	12	4	80	GCE17	21	5	70

As seen in Table 2, EC1 is the most fully disclosed indicator among Economic Performance Indicators. Conversely, EC6 is the one has the most undisclosed among other indicators.

Table 2: Frequency Distrubition Results of Disclosures on Economic Performance Indicators

Economic Performance Indicators	Frequency			Economic Performance Indicators	Frequency		
	Undis closed	Partially Disclosed	Fully Disclosed		Undis closed	Partially Disclosed	Fully Disclosed
EC1	7	21	69	EC6	39	13	44
EC2	34	26	36	EC7	29	22	45
EC3	29	18	49	EC8	11	21	64
EC4	32	5	59	EC9	29	27	40
EC5	36	21	39				

According to the frequency distribution results in Table 3, the most fully disclosed indicator of environmental performance indicators is EN8. In other respect, EN19 and EN24 are the most undisclosed indicators.

Table 3: Frequency Distrubition Results of Disclosures on Environmental Performance Indicators

Environmental Performance Indicators	Frequency			Environmental Performance Indicators	Frequency		
	Undis closed	Partially Disclosed	Fully Disclosed		Undis closed	Partially Disclosed	Fully Disclosed
EN1	55	11	30	EN16	33	11	52
EN2	50	15	31	EN17	58	7	31
EN3	18	17	61	EN18	22	21	53
EN4	31	19	46	EN19	75	1	20
EN5	18	20	58	EN20	62	11	23
EN6	26	15	55	EN21	41	10	45
EN7	36	23	37	EN22	9	29	58
EN8	14	12	69	EN23	54	3	39
EN9	48	4	44	EN24	75	7	14
EN10	62	9	25	EN25	55	5	36
EN11	37	2	57	EN26	14	20	62
EN12	53	5	38	EN27	48	16	32
EN13	49	10	37	EN28	39	1	56
EN14	48	15	33	EN29	45	23	28
EN15	70	-	26	EN30	44	12	40

Frequency distribution results in Table 4 show that the most fully disclosed indicator of Labour Practices and Decent Work Performance Indicators is LA1. Contrarily, LA9 is the most undisclosed indicator.

Table 4: Frequency Distribution Results of Disclosures on Labour Practices and Decent Work Performance Indicators

Labour Practices and Decent Work Performance Indicators	Frequency			Labour Practices and Decent Work Performance Indicators	Frequency		
	Undisclosed	Partially Disclosed	Fully Disclosed		Undisclosed	Partially Disclosed	Fully Disclosed
LA1	2	15	79	LA8	21	19	56
LA2	14	28	54	LA9	49	8	39
LA3	32	4	60	LA10	7	32	57
LA4	30	-	66	LA11	18	17	61
LA5	25	5	66	LA12	13	19	64
LA6	42	7	47	LA13	14	22	60
LA7	16	28	52	LA14	31	6	59

As seen in Table 5, while the most fully disclosed indicator of human rights performance indicators is HR6, the most undisclosed indicator is HR3.

Table 5: Frequency Distribution Results of Disclosures on Human Rights Performance Indicators

Human Rights Performance Indicators	Frequency			Human Rights Performance Indicators	Frequency		
	Undisclosed	Partially Disclosed	Fully Disclosed		Undisclosed	Partially Disclosed	Fully Disclosed
HR1	50	20	26	HR6	14	8	74
HR2	42	20	34	HR7	19	8	69
HR3	58	9	29	HR8	54	-	42
HR4	18	10	68	HR9	54	5	37
HR5	30	10	56				

Table 6 indicates that PR5 is the most fully disclosed indicator of Product Responsibility Performance Indicators. Thereagainst, PR4 is the most undisclosed indicator.

Table 6: Frequency Distribution Results of Disclosures on Product Responsibility Performance Indicators

Product Responsibility Performance Indicators	Frequency			Product Responsibility Performance Indicators	Frequency		
	Undisclosed	Partially Disclosed	Fully Disclosed		Undisclosed	Partially Disclosed	Fully Disclosed
PR1	44	11	41	PR6	36	12	48
PR2	52	1	43	PR7	48	4	44
PR3	32	6	58	PR8	40	5	51
PR4	50	1	45	PR9	43	3	50
PR5	9	14	73				

According to the frequency distribution results in Table 7, while the most fully disclosed indicator of Social Performance Indicators is SO4, the most undisclosed indicator is SO7.

Table 7: Frequency Distrubition Results of Disclosures on Social Performance Indicators

Social Performan ce Indicators	Frequency			Social Performance Indicators	Frequency		
	Undis closed	Partially Disclosed	Fully Disclosed		Undis closed	Partially Disclosed	Fully Disclosed
SO1	27	26	43	SO5	46	9	41
SO2	28	29	39	SO6	49	2	45
SO3	33	16	47	SO7	51	1	44
SO4	25	13	58	SO8	47	-	49

When the study results are summarized, it is seen that disclosures on Strategy and Profile Indicators are more than disclosures on Management Approach and Performance Indicators in GRI reports of companies in Turkey. Aktaş et al. (2013) and Maubane et al. (2014) concluded similar results in their studies. It is believed that the main reason for this results is additional cost of technical knowledge and calculation for economic, environmental and social performance indicators.

5. Conclusion

Growing significance of sustainability reveals that companies are an important tool to bring current situation about sustainability practices in the World into view. Therefore, corporate dimension of sustainability has emerged. Corporate sustainability, called business sustainability, deals with economic, environmental, social and managerial issues. Besides, developments related to corporate sustainability are tracked through sustainability reports.

This study indicates that disclosures on Strategy and Profile Indicators are more than disclosures on Management Approach and Performance Indicators in Turkey. The most disclosed indicators in the Management Approach and Performance Indicators are respectively economic, social and environmental performance indicators. Economic performance indicators are the most disclosed indicators since companies are already preparing their financial reports. However, environmental performance indicators are the least disclosed indicators in Turkey since their calculation and reporting is costly and requires extra time and qualified staff. On the other hand, there is an increasing interest in sustainability reporting in Turkey. The lack of relevant regulations and qualified staffs and the additional costs of sustainability reporting can be considered as the reasons of insufficient number of prepared sustainability reports in Turkey.

It is believed that results of this study may provide guidance to academics for future studies on sustainability issue. Besides, it can help them to see deficiencies related to sustainability in the literature. It is expected that this study will also provide awareness on sustainability and its importance by academics and all of the other information users. In addition, the study results may help business managers to improve their performance on sustainability and policy makers to make new regulations on sustainability reporting. Moreover, this study will contribute significantly to the literature since new researches in Turkey have been started studies related to sustainability, which has been already the subject of many international conferences and seminars in recent years.

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